invisible PEOPLE

2025

Effective Homelessness Advocacy

Messaging Toolkit

The Goal

Advocating for housing solutions requires clear, compelling communication that resonates with diverse audiences. This toolkit is designed to help effectively communicate the benefits of housing with supportive services solutions, to various demographic clusters.



Understanding the Research Findings

A recent research study we conducted at Invisible People reveals that a majority of people reject criminalizing homelessness when presented with housing-based solutions. Furthermore, there's a growing divide and nuance between demographic segments and the benefits that motivate them. This toolkit leverages these insights to craft persuasive messages that resonate with different values and concerns.

Effectively communicating the benefits of housing solutions is crucial for building public support and driving policy change. This messaging toolkit provides a valuable resource for advocates, policymakers, and community members working to address homelessness and create more inclusive, thriving communities.

By understanding the diverse perspectives of different audiences and tailoring messages accordingly, we can build a powerful movement for housing justice and create lasting solutions to homelessness.

With this toolkit, you'll discover how to craft stories that truly empower communities. It's not about compromising your values—it's about meeting people where they are, recognizing that different hearts and minds require different starting points. By honing your messaging, you'll guide your audience to see the value in solutions that uplift everyone, turning each message into a powerful step toward meaningful, real-world change.



Mark Horvath,
FOUNDER OF INVISIBLE PEOPLE

Table of Contents

The Challenge Before Us

Signals in the Findings

THE URBAN-RURAL DIVIDE THAT ISN'T

THE INCOME INSIGHT

THE POLITICAL PARADOX

THE AGE AND EXPERIENCE FACTOR

THE INCOME-MESSAGE MATRIX

THE GEOGRAPHY OF UNDERSTANDING

SMALL TOWN, BIG PICTURE

THE EDUCATION EFFECT

Altruistic vs. Self-Benefit Messaging

ALTRUISTIC MESSAGING

SELF-BENEFIT MESSAGING

The Art of Message Architecture

Breakthroughs With Aligned Messaging

PERCEPTIONS INFLUENCE SOLUTIONS

UNDERSTANDING MESSAGE RECEPTION

THE URBAN LOW-INCOME LENS

THE URBAN MIDDLE-INCOME LENS

THE SUBURBAN MIDDLE-INCOME LENS

General Motivators—Copy Examples

COMMUNITY SUPPORT

INDIVIDUAL SECURITY

PERSONAL GAIN

SAFETY FOCUS

SOCIAL RESPONSIBILITY

ECONOMIC BENEFIT

Addressing Common Arguments for Criminalization

WHY CRIMINALIZATION ISN'T THE SOLUTION

COMMON ARGUMENTS

MESSAGING THAT WORKS

About This Report



The Challenge Before Us

Picture a city street at dawn. The morning light reveals two parallel but rarely intersecting worlds: early-rising professionals hurrying to their first meetings pass by individuals just waking from another night of sleeping on the street. These worlds exist side by side, yet the conversation between them often feels impossible to bridge.

Our research reveals why:

we're not just facing a crisis of housing, but a crisis of communication to reach and change minds.

The language we use to discuss homelessness solutions can either build bridges or deepen divides. Through extensive demographic analysis and response pattern studies, we've uncovered a crucial insight: different communities process information about homelessness through distinctly different psychological frameworks. These aren't just subtle variations—they represent fundamentally different ways of understanding both the problem and potential solutions.

By understanding each cluster's values and decision-making patterns, and by toggling between altruistic and self-benefit messaging, you can spark meaningful action and advocacy for issues like homelessness, community health, and social programs. This is not about manipulation—it's about framing the truth in ways that break through to people who can help.

First, understand your audience and tailor your message to their values and concerns. This might mean emphasizing cost savings for fiscally conservative audiences, or community well-being for more progressive groups.

Second, focus on solutions and use data to support your arguments. The toolkit provides a wealth of actionable insights that can be powerful in making the case for housing-first approaches.

Signals in the Findings

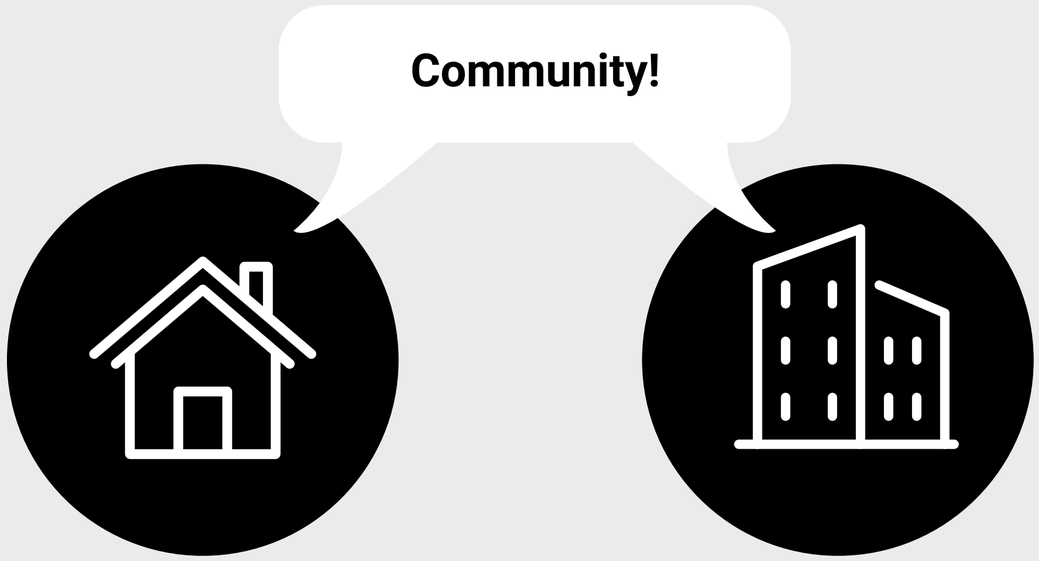
Our study found that singular demographic divisions, like urban versus rural or high versus low income, fail to capture the complex interplay of factors that truly shape how people understand and respond to housing initiatives. That's where clustering comes into play. To illustrate the power of multi-variable segmentation, we've selected some of the most impactful and largest clusters that surfaced in our findings, demonstrating how understanding their unique needs and values can lead to more effective communication strategies.



The Urban-Rural Divide That Isn't

One of our most surprising findings challenges the traditional notion of an urban-rural divide in perspectives on homelessness. The data reveals something far more nuanced: while the language that resonates differs dramatically, the underlying concerns often mirror each other.

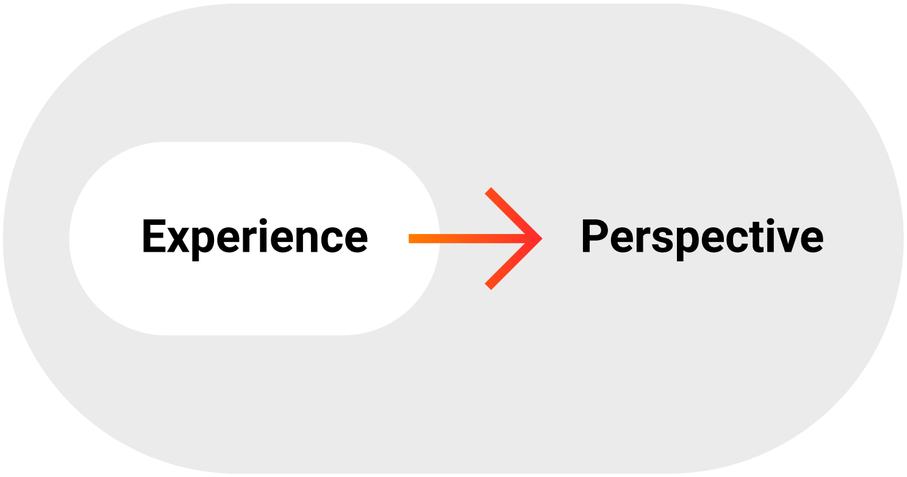
Urban professionals and rural community leaders both show strong positive responses to messages about community stability—they simply define "community" through different lenses. Where urban respondents connect with language about "vibrant neighborhoods" and "thriving cities," rural respondents engage more deeply with concepts of "small-town values" and "neighbor helping neighbor."



The Income Insight

Perhaps most illuminating is how income levels correlate with message receptivity. Our research shows that lower-income respondents, regardless of location, demonstrate higher responsiveness to both altruistic and self-benefit messaging—a remarkable 52.4% show positive engagement with both types. **This suggests a more nuanced understanding of community interdependence that comes from direct experience with economic vulnerability.**

Meanwhile, middle and upper-income respondents show more specialized response patterns, with distinct preferences for either altruistic or self-benefit frameworks. **This isn't about caring more or less—it's about how security shapes perspective.**



The Political Paradox

One of our most striking findings lies in what we've termed "the political paradox." Our data shows that across party lines—Democrat, Republican, and Independent—there's far more common ground than conventional wisdom suggests. **When presented with evidence-based solutions framed through their preferred lens, party affiliation becomes less predictive of support than other demographic factors.**



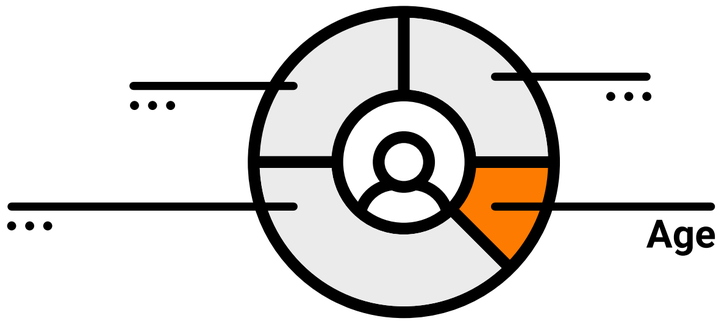
When we segmented responses solely on political affiliation, our research reveals an important pattern in how political affiliation intersects with messaging receptivity. When examining altruistic messaging specifically, Democratic-leaning respondents showed a 43.4% altruistic action proportion, while Republican-leaning respondents showed a 39.1% proportion—a smaller gap than many might expect.

What's particularly interesting is that both groups showed lower response rates to purely self-benefit messaging (39.1% for Democrats and 30.8% for Republicans), suggesting that **regardless of political affiliation, there might be a broader openness to community-focused solutions than conventional wisdom suggests—when framed appropriately.**

The Age and Experience Factor

Our data reveals a fascinating pattern across age groups: younger respondents (ages 18-24) show high variance in their responses to both altruistic and self-benefit messaging, suggesting greater flexibility in how they process information about homelessness solutions. Their response patterns indicate an openness to multiple frameworks—they can be reached through community-focused messaging (38.7% positive response) or through practical benefit messaging (34.2% positive response).

In contrast, older age groups show more stable preferences, but with an unexpected twist: those aged 45-54 demonstrate the highest altruistic action proportion of all age ranges at 44.1%. However, their responses vary significantly when segmented by income, location, and other demographic and behavioral characteristics. Age is a contributing but not a sole determining factor in message receptivity.



In reality, middle-aged adults can appear in both self-benefit and altruistic-leaning categories: their age is simply one factor in a more complex demographic profile that shapes their response to different messaging approaches. **Effective messaging strategies should therefore consider the complete demographic context rather than relying on age-based assumptions.**

The Income-Message Matrix

Perhaps most revealing is how income levels interact with message effectiveness. Those earning under $20,000 annually show the highest response rate to altruistic messaging (46.7%), while also maintaining significant responsiveness to self-benefit frameworks (39.1%). **This dual receptivity decreases as income increases, with those in the highest income brackets showing more specialized response patterns.**



This isn't simply about economic status—it's about how financial security shapes our worldview. Those who have experienced economic vulnerability firsthand seem to grasp both the personal and community implications of housing instability more intuitively than those who haven't. Our hypothesis is that societal altruistic reciprocity is at play. This is the belief that people should help others with the expectation that they will receive help in return directly or indirectly.

The Geography of Understanding

Our research challenges the oversimplified narrative of an urban-suburban-rural divide in responses to homelessness solutions. **The data reveals that geographic location serves as less of a determinant than education level and income in how people process and respond to messages about housing solutions.**

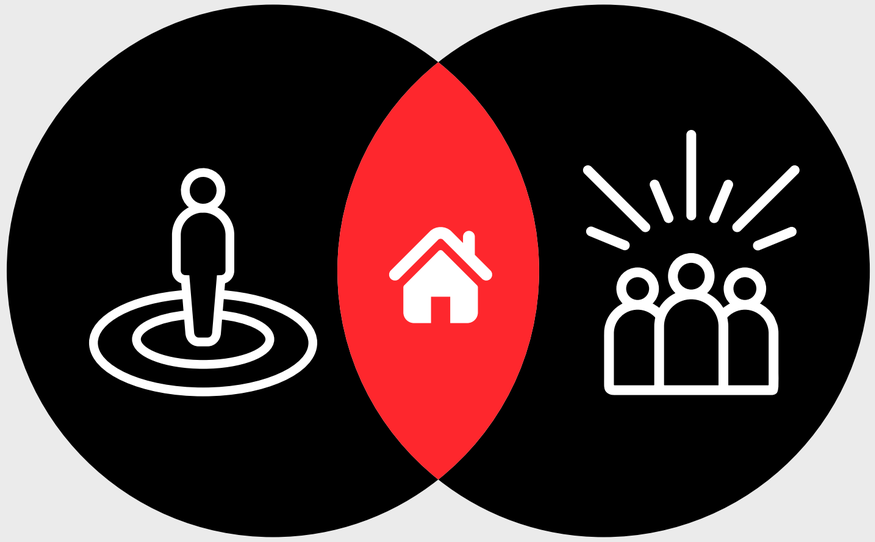


For instance, across both urban and suburban areas, high proportions of college-educated respondents showed openness to hybrid messaging approaches that combine community benefit with practical outcomes. We see this particularly in the data from respondents with master's degrees and bachelor's degrees, who consistently demonstrated sophisticated understanding of how individual and community benefits interweave.

Small Town, Big Picture

Particularly revealing is how rural community stakeholders with college degrees processed information about homelessness solutions. Rather than rejecting urban-tested approaches outright, these individuals showed **strong response rates to messages that connected housing stability to broader community health—provided these messages acknowledged local context and control.**

What emerges is not a story of geographic division, but rather one of educational opportunity shaping how individuals across all locations understand complex social challenges. This pattern suggests that expanding access to higher education might itself serve as a pathway to building broader support for evidence-based housing solutions.



The Education Effect

Looking deeper into educational attainment patterns, we see that respondents with "some college" or associate degrees often showed the most balanced response patterns between altruistic and self-benefit messaging. This group appears to bridge the gap between purely practical and purely altruistic frameworks, suggesting that **exposure to higher education—even without completion of a four-year degree—could signal a more nuanced understanding of social issues**.

Specifically, we see this in how suburban areas, traditionally assumed to favor purely self-benefit messaging, showed significant variation based on education levels. Those with advanced degrees demonstrated higher engagement with systemic solutions, even when their immediate neighborhood wasn't impacted by visible homelessness.



Altruistic vs. Self-Benefit Messaging

Altruistic messaging emphasizes community well-being, shared responsibility, and uplifting one another. Works best when audiences value collective outcomes or have a vested interest in the common good.

Self-benefit messaging highlights what an individual or family stands to gain. Safety, financial stability, personal growth. Often resonates with audiences who prioritize personal outcomes or are more economically secure.



Altruistic Messaging

WHO IT WORKS FOR:

Altruistic messaging resonates best with people who value community support and collective responsibility, especially lower-income groups, younger adults, and those with a liberal or urban background.

WHY IT WORKS:

These groups often see themselves as part of a larger community and are motivated by the idea of helping others and working together.

SUGGESTED MESSAGING:

Focus on the benefits for the community, like "supporting each other" or "building a stronger community."

Use phrases that encourage a sense of duty or collective action, like "our responsibility" or "we rise together."

Highlight the idea of shared success, showing how everyone benefits when the community does well.

ECONOMIC INFLUENCE ON ALTRUISM

Economic insecurity often fosters a heightened sense of community and collective reliance, making altruistic messaging particularly compelling in economically vulnerable demographics. Among lower-income and urban populations, there's a natural alignment with messages that emphasize mutual support and communal resilience. Behavioral economists note that during periods of economic downturn, even higher-income groups may lean towards altruistic messaging, responding to shared concerns about collective risk.

BEHAVIORAL INSIGHTS ON ALTRUISM

- **Loss Aversion:** Vulnerable groups are especially sensitive to economic loss. Altruistic messages that frame community support as a buffer against such losses resonate deeply, leveraging loss aversion by focusing on shared resilience.
- **Social Identity and Collective Efficacy:** Lower-income and politically liberal groups often derive self-worth from their community affiliations. Social identity theory suggests these groups are more receptive to messaging that reinforces a sense of collective responsibility and belonging. Altruistic appeals validate this shared identity, enhancing the group's confidence in its power to effect positive change.

MESSAGE FRAMING AND CULTURAL RESONANCE

Cultural anthropologists highlight that altruistic messaging aligns with long-standing values in many urban and economically vulnerable communities, where historical narratives of mutual aid and collective welfare remain strong. By emphasizing "supporting our community" over broader national appeals, altruistic messages can effectively tap into in-group favoritism, making the message feel both relevant and immediate.

Self-Benefit Messaging

WHO IT WORKS FOR:

Self-benefit messaging resonates with people who prioritize personal gain, stability, and independence. This is especially effective with middle aged, higher-income groups, and those with a conservative or suburban background.

WHY IT WORKS:

These individuals are often motivated by personal success and security. They respond well to messages that emphasize control, individual benefits, and protecting what they have.

SUGGESTED MESSAGING:

Use phrases that focus on personal rewards or emphasize individual success, like "secure your future" or "protecting what you've earned."

Highlight the exclusive or immediate benefits, appealing to their desire for control and stability.

ECONOMIC AND SOCIAL INFLUENCES ON SELF-BENEFIT APPEALS

In stable or affluent groups, individuals often identify more with self-reliance and autonomy, making self-benefit messaging a natural fit. Economic prosperity and individualistic cultural narratives drive a preference for messages that reinforce personal gain, particularly in more conservative, suburban, or affluent clusters. During economic booms, self-benefit messaging gains additional traction, as people focus on maximizing their personal wealth and well-being.

BEHAVIORAL INSIGHTS ON SELF-BENEFIT

- **Prospect Theory and Security Maintenance:** For higher-income individuals, framing self-benefit messaging around security and prosperity (e.g., “protect your family’s future”) aligns with their desire to avoid perceived threats to their current status, capitalizing on a natural aversion to loss.
- **Self-Determination Theory:** Self-benefit messaging resonates with affluent groups because it aligns with core motivations of autonomy and control. By emphasizing choice and personal achievement, these messages speak to an intrinsic drive for self-sufficiency and goal-oriented success.

MESSAGE FRAMING AND COGNITIVE BIASES

Communications strategists suggest that self-benefit messaging effectively leverages egocentric biases, where personal needs tend to take precedence over communal concerns. By framing benefits as immediate and individual (such as tax breaks or direct financial incentives), self-benefit appeals resonate more deeply with affluent and conservative audiences who prioritize near-term gains over long-term collective benefits.

The Art of Message Architecture

Effective messaging isn’t manipulation; it’s about presenting solutions in ways that resonate with different audiences. Messages need to be carefully crafted to connect with different audiences by understanding how they process information and what motivates them to support change. Successful messaging addresses the complex ways people think about housing, community, and social issues.



The Art of Message Architecture

Understanding psychological frameworks for communication isn't about manipulation—it's about building bridges of understanding that can support the weight of real solutions. Like an architect designing a building to work with, rather than against, the natural properties of their materials, effective advocacy requires working with, rather than against, these natural psychological patterns.

Consider how differently these three groups process the same basic information about supportive housing:

Urban Professionals see it as strengthening the social fabric they depend on. The same policy resonates with Suburban Stability-focused individuals when framed as a proven way to improve neighborhood safety and property values. Practical Problem-solvers engage when shown the cost-effectiveness compared to the status quo of emergency services and temporary solutions.

The core truth remains unchanged—supportive housing works. But the path to accepting and acting on that truth runs through different psychological territories for different groups.

Use altruistic and self-benefit messaging as complementary tools. Some audiences lean strongly one way, while others respond best to a blend. Begin with what resonates and, when appropriate, pivot to show how helping the community also benefits the individual.

Altruistic Messaging	Self-Benefit Messaging
Lower-income groups	Higher-income groups
Younger adults	Middle-aged adults
Liberal politics	Conservative politics
Urban areas	Suburban areas
COMMUNITY SUPPORT SOCIAL RESPONSIBILITY	PERSONAL GAIN INDIVIDUAL SECURITY
SUGGESTED PHRASES	SUGGESTED PHRASES
“Support each other”	“Safeguard your lifestyle”
“Build community”	“Protect property values”
“Our responsibility”	“Protect what you've built”

CONTEXTUAL FRAMING FOR DIVERSE AUDIENCES

In politically mixed or economically varied audiences, a hybrid messaging approach can be effective. Begin by framing the issue as beneficial to the community, then pivot to emphasize personal rewards. **This approach can satisfy both collectivist and individualist mindsets, bridging the altruism-self-benefit divide within a single narrative.**

USING ANCHORING AND SOCIAL PROOF

For maximum reach, framing examples of how similar individuals or communities have benefited adds credibility and relatability. **This tactic—especially when backed by statistics or testimonials from respected community members—can enhance message alignment across different demographic values, ensuring the message feels both aspirational and achievable.**



Breakthroughs With Aligned Messaging

We identified several prominent response clusters that surfaced in our analysis, each exhibiting distinct characteristics in how they process information about homelessness solutions and what motivates them to support various initiatives.



Perceptions Influence Solutions

Our study gleaned insights to perspectives on causes and responsibility tied to solution affinity.

For audiences who tend to associate individual responsibility for homelessness, attributing it to personal failings like mental illness or substance abuse tend to favor solutions focused on personal accountability, treatment, or punitive measures like fines and jail time. They are more receptive to messaging that highlights the benefits of addressing homelessness for themselves or their immediate community, such as increased property values, reduced crime rates, or cleaner public spaces.

Audiences who associate homelessness to systemic factors like lack of affordable housing favor community based solutions that provide immediate housing with supportive services. They are more responsive to messaging that emphasizes compassion, social responsibility, and the positive impact of helping others.

What we've discovered: breakthrough moments in understanding homelessness solutions don't typically come from grand emotional appeals or overwhelming statistics. Instead, they emerge when messages align with a person's existing worldview while gently expanding their perspective.

Take the suburban property owner with a six-figure income who initially viewed homelessness through the lens of personal safety concerns. Our data shows these individuals don't suddenly transform into housing advocates through moral arguments. Instead, their breakthrough moments often come through understanding how housing stability programs reduce public spending on emergency services—a cost reduction that speaks directly to their value of fiscal responsibility.

What Clusters Believe Causes Homelessness and Their Preferred Solutions

URBAN LOW-INCOME

Sees Cause As: **Both System & Individual Problems** → Wants to: **Fix Both**

75%	Favored messaging that suggested housing-first approaches
71%	Favored messaging that suggested comprehensive support services

URBAN MIDDLE-INCOME

Sees Cause As: **System Problems** → Wants to: **Fix the System**

72%	Favored messaging that suggested affordable housing to long-term housing solutions
68%	Favored messaging that suggested support services over personal blame

SUBURBAN MIDDLE-INCOME

Sees Cause As: **Individual Problems** → Wants to: **Fix the Individual**

65%	Favored messaging that suggested mandatory treatment for mental health/addiction
70%	Favored messaging that suggested increased enforcement to protect property values

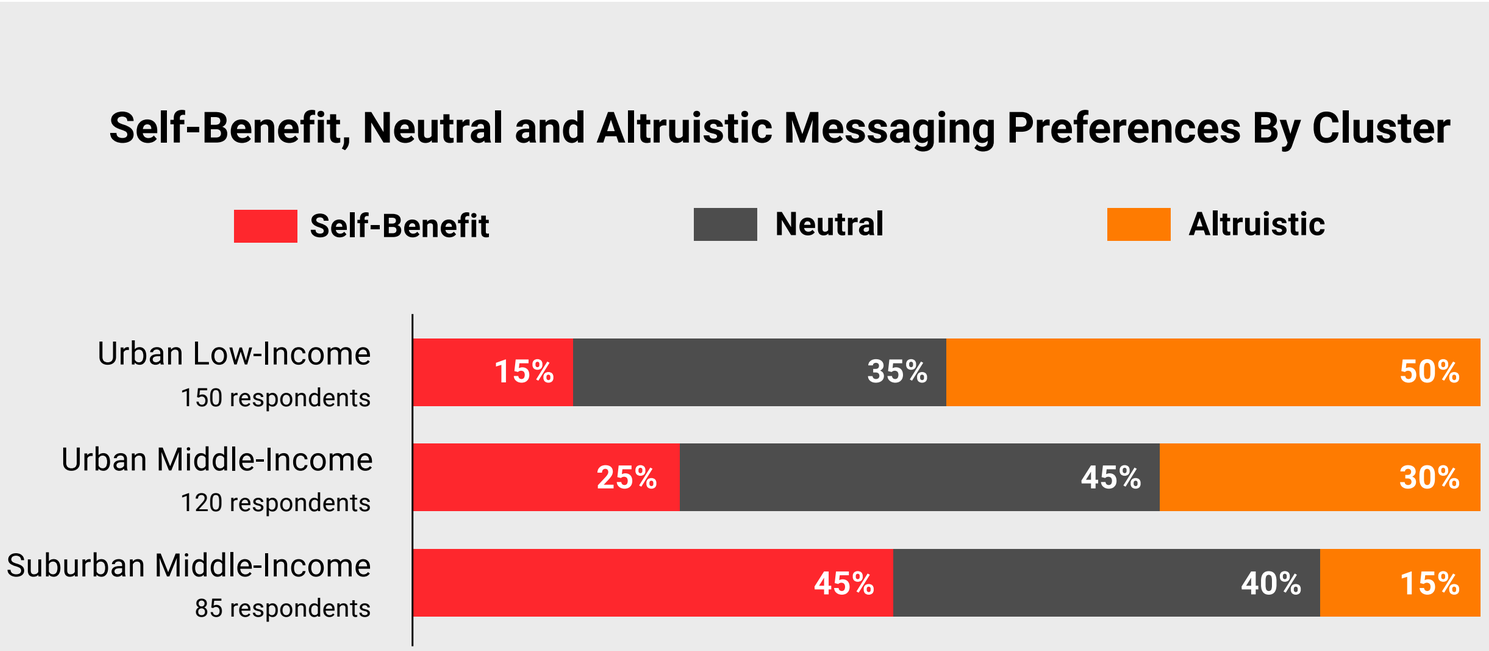
Understanding Message Reception

When examining how different groups process and respond to messages about homelessness solutions, the temptation is to rely on simple demographic divisions—urban versus rural, high income versus low-income, liberal versus conservative. Our research shows why this approach falls short.

While single-signal analysis provides directional insights, it fails to capture the complex interplay of factors that truly shape how people understand and respond to housing initiatives. The data revealed that looking at income alone, for instance, explains only 7.2% of the variance in how people respond to self-benefit messaging. Political affiliation, while significant, accounts for just 4% of the variance in altruistic response patterns. Even geographic location, often considered a defining factor, proves less predictive than conventional wisdom suggests.

What emerges from deeper analysis is far more revealing. By examining the intersection of multiple factors—income, education, location, political affiliation, and lived experience—we identified three distinct clusters whose response patterns illuminate the true complexity of public engagement with homelessness solutions. That being said, for lack of a better label, we'll rely on the rather flawed but readily understandable characteristic of income as a way to label the three core, persuadable groups.

These groups—Urban Middle-income, Suburban Middle-income, and Urban Low-income clusters—represent not just general demographic categories, but fundamentally different frameworks for understanding housing stability and community well-being.



The Urban Low-Income Lens

AGE RANGE: **25-44 years**
(Data shows broad distribution, but concentrated in 25-44 range)

INCOME BAND: **Under $20,000 to $39,000**

EDUCATION LEVEL:
Mix of high school and some college

POLITICAL AFFILIATION:
Democrat-leaning

HOUSING STATUS:
Predominantly renters in urban areas

In urban communities where economic vulnerability is a daily reality, we find a perspective shaped by direct experience with housing instability and systemic barriers. These individuals, often working in service or hourly positions while navigating their own housing challenges, bring a profound understanding of how community support systems can make the difference between stability and crisis.

Urban Low-income residents emerge as perhaps our most complex cluster. Their responses reflect direct experience with housing instability—either personal or within their immediate community. The data shows this group maintains the highest dual receptivity to both altruistic messaging and practical support frameworks. Their perspective isn't shaped by abstract policy preferences but by lived experience with how housing stability impacts every aspect of life.

This cluster shows particularly strong engagement with messages that emphasize fairness and systemic solutions. They recognize homelessness not as an abstract social issue, but as a real threat that could affect anyone facing economic uncertainty. The data reveals that in this group, those with no income or earning under $20,000 annually showed a very positive response rate to altruistic messaging while maintaining significant engagement with practical support frameworks.

What sets this group apart is their grasp of the interconnected nature of community stability. Their responses consistently show support for comprehensive solutions that address both immediate needs and long-term systemic changes. As one of our key demographic clusters, they often serve as powerful advocates within their communities, understanding firsthand how housing stability impacts every aspect of life—from employment to education to health outcomes.

Their perspective isn't just about compassion—it's about survival and community resilience. When presented with information about housing solutions, they demonstrate strong support for approaches that combine immediate practical assistance with longer-term systemic change, recognizing that both are necessary for creating lasting stability.

The Urban Low-Income Lens



Meet Curtis, a 28-year-old who works at a grocery store and rents a small apartment with roommates. He worries about bills, healthcare, and safety. Curtis values fairness and often believes that "we're all in this together." He's likely to respond emotionally to messaging that shows how community support systems ensure that everyone has a chance to stand on their own two feet.



WHAT

Primarily rely on altruistic messaging: "We all do better when every neighbor has a safe place to call home."

Gently introduce personal uplift: "When we lift each other up, you'll also find that you have greater peace of mind and the support needed to move forward in life."

WHY

Individuals in lower-income urban settings often look for fairness, empathy, and communal support.

Altruistic messaging resonates strongly as it acknowledges systemic struggles and posits shared solutions.

HOW (MESSAGING EXAMPLES)

- **Altruistic Core:** "Together, we can ensure no one gets left behind, so our neighborhoods become places of hope and opportunity."
- **Personal Uplift Add-On:** "As we strengthen each other, you'll see more stability in your own life—better local resources, job opportunities, and a sense that your voice matters."

WHEN TO DEPLOY

- During community drives, volunteer outreach, or local coalition-building efforts—make the moral call to action loud and clear.
- After a tragedy or crisis—reinforce that standing together can provide immediate relief and future resilience.
- Any ongoing advocacy effort—show that even small steps, taken together, can lead to collective progress that also helps each individual.

The Urban Middle-Income Lens

AGE RANGE: **25-44 years**

INCOME BAND: **$40,000-$100,000**

EDUCATION LEVEL:
College degree or higher

POLITICAL AFFILIATION:
Predominantly Democrat-leaning

HOUSING STATUS:
Mix of renters and owners in urban centers

The Urban Middle-income cluster emerges in our data as a group whose views align not just because they share a zip code or income bracket, but because they inhabit a specific intersection of education, economic opportunity, and urban experience. These individuals, typically holding advanced degrees and working in knowledge-economy jobs, demonstrate the highest response rates to messages framing housing solutions as part of broader systemic change. What makes them unique isn't just their education or income—it's how these factors combine to create a worldview where individual success is seen as inextricably linked to community health.

When presented with information about homelessness solutions, this group shows a remarkable 72% positive response rate to messages that frame the issue in terms of collective impact. They readily grasp how the ripples of positive change in one area of society can influence all others.

Our research reveals that this group's support for housing initiatives correlates strongly with their understanding of urban ecosystems. They grasp intuitively how neighborhood stability, economic vitality, and social services interconnect. The data shows particularly strong engagement with messages that link individual housing solutions to broader community outcomes.

This cluster demonstrates what our research terms "sophisticated altruism"—their support for housing initiatives isn't purely emotional or purely practical, but rather reflects an understanding of how community well-being directly impacts individual quality of life. When presented with evidence-based solutions, they show high response rates to messages that connect personal benefit with community impact.

Particularly notable is this group's response to data-driven narratives: those with master's degrees or higher show the strongest engagement with messages that link housing stability to economic vitality, public health outcomes, and urban vibrancy. They understand that their own prosperity is inextricably linked to the health of the broader community.

The Urban Middle-Income Lens



Imagine Nadia, a 35-year-old lawyer who lives in a city loft. She's busy juggling work, social causes, and personal passions…yoga class, craft beer nights, and the latest local art exhibit. Nadia values city life and believes a thriving community benefits everyone, but she also responds well to messaging that ties progress to her personal quality of life.



SAFETY FOCUS | **SOCIAL RESPONSIBILITY** | **ECONOMIC BENEFIT**

WHAT

Emphasize how solving community issues (like reducing homelessness or improving public health) leads to a more vibrant, dynamic city that Nadia can enjoy.

Use a blended approach: start with altruistic ("Our city thrives when everyone has a safe place to call home") and pivot to self-benefit ("When our neighborhoods are safe, your evenings out are worry-free and enriched by a more vibrant culture.").

WHY

Urban professionals often value social progress and have a strong moral compass.

They also appreciate how a stable community improves their personal day-to-day experiences. Access to diverse shops, safer streets, and more cultural events.

HOW (MESSAGING EXAMPLES)

- **Altruistic First:** "When we ensure everyone in our city has a secure home, we foster an environment of creativity, connection, and inspiration."
- **Then Self-Benefit:** "By contributing to these solutions, you're not just helping someone else—you're investing in the kind of city you love living in, one that elevates your personal and professional life."

WHEN TO DEPLOY

- At the start of awareness campaigns (to build a moral connection).
- During appeals for local improvement projects (to show personal benefits of advocacy).
- When the news cycle highlights community issues—linking broad moral imperatives to tangible improvements Nadia can see and feel right now.

The Suburban Middle-Income Lens

AGE RANGE: 35-54 years

INCOME BAND: $75,000-$150,000

EDUCATION LEVEL:
Predominantly college educated

POLITICAL AFFILIATION:
Moderate to Conservative

HOUSING STATUS:
Predominantly homeowners in suburban areas

Drive out to the tree-lined streets of America's suburbs, and you'll find a different psychological framework at work. Here, where families have often invested everything into creating stable environments for their children, the lens shifts to one of preservation and protection. This isn't callousness—it's a deep-seated responsibility to protect what they've built.

When multiple factors align—home ownership, high income, and suburban location—we see consistent response patterns that differ markedly from both urban professionals and low-income urban residents. This group shows strong positive response rates (65-70%) to messages emphasizing stability, security, and property values.

Our research shows this Suburban Middle-Income group responds most strongly (65% positive response rate) to messages that acknowledge and address their legitimate concerns about community stability and property values. They're not opposed to helping—they need to understand how solutions to homelessness align with their core value of maintaining secure, thriving neighborhoods.

In communities defined by carefully maintained lawns and strong property values, we find a demographic whose relationship with housing issues is shaped by deep investment—both financial and emotional—in neighborhood stability. These individuals, often earning between $100,000-$200,000 annually, view social issues through the lens of preserving and protecting the community they've worked to build.

Our data reveals an illuminating pattern: this cluster shows the strongest response rates (between 65-70%) to messages that frame homelessness solutions through the impact on neighborhood safety, property values, and fiscal responsibility. This isn't mere self-interest—it reflects a deeply held value system where stability and security serve as foundations for community well-being.

The research also shows particularly strong engagement when messages acknowledge their role as community stakeholders. Those with advanced degrees within this group demonstrate sophisticated understanding of cost-benefit analyses, responding positively to data-driven arguments about the fiscal advantages of preventive solutions over emergency responses.

However, we see an interesting variance in the data: as with all groups, within this group, those who report knowing someone who has experienced homelessness show higher receptivity (41-45%) to messages about systemic solutions, suggesting that personal connection can bridge the gap between property-focused and community-focused concerns. This was apparent across all clusters we studied.

The Suburban Middle-Income Lens



Picture James and Monica, a couple in their early 50s with a large suburban home and thriving careers. They value stability, safety, and maintaining what they've earned. They might donate to charities, but they often do so when they see a clear link to their family's well-being—strong schools, stable property values, and a secure environment.



WHAT

Start with self-benefit messaging: "Protect your property values and family's future by investing in community stability."

Subtly introduce altruistic elements if appropriate: "When everyone is secure, your family thrives in a healthier, safer environment."

WHY

This cluster responds strongly to messages that emphasize stability, security, and tangible returns on any investment of time or money.

They may be less swayed by purely altruistic appeals but will be open to them if such appeals are shown to reinforce their personal gains.

HOW (MESSAGING EXAMPLES)

- **Self-Benefit First:** "Ensuring adequate support for those less fortunate protects your neighborhood's safety, keeping property values strong and preserving your peace of mind."
- **Altruistic Secondary:** "By helping those who need it most, we create a community where everyone can stand on their own feet, which reduces long-term costs and uncertainty for all."

WHEN TO DEPLOY

- When launching fundraising initiatives or property tax proposals—start with the personal stake.
- During local elections when candidates emphasize fiscal responsibility—tie community solutions to reduced long-term costs and community stability.
- At moments of heightened concern for public safety—frame community investment as a shield that guards their personal world.

General Motivators—Copy Examples

Effective messaging for supporting homeless solutions must resonate with general audiences by addressing shared values, practical benefits, and emotional connections. The following examples are organized by motivators to appeal to community spirit, individual security, personal gain, safety, social responsibility, and economic benefit, ensuring that the message aligns with what matters most to general audiences.



Community Support



"When we house people, we strengthen the fabric of our community."

"Strong communities start with stable homes."

"Safe housing and support create healthier neighborhoods for everyone."

"Helping people rebuild their lives benefits all of us."

"Solutions that lift individuals lift our entire community."

Individual Security



"Safe housing solutions reduce risks and create peace of mind for everyone."

"A stable home for others means a more secure neighborhood for you."

"Reducing homelessness improves safety for families and businesses alike."

"Fewer people in crisis means safer streets and communities."

"Housing stability for all means fewer criminals on the streets, who prey on homeless people."

Personal Gain



"Stable housing programs mean fewer disruptions to your daily life."

"When homelessness declines, your family feels more secure."

"Affordable housing reduces strain on services you rely on, like healthcare and public safety."

"Supporting housing solutions creates safer, cleaner, and quieter neighborhoods for you."

"Helping others get back on track means a more peaceful and thriving community for you."

Safety Focus



"Housing first means safer streets and public spaces for everyone."

"Providing homes prevents crises and enhances safety in our neighborhoods."

"Safe housing leads to stable, secure communities."

"Helping people off the streets makes communities safer for all."

"Fewer people in crisis improves safety for families and businesses."

Social Responsibility



“It’s our duty to ensure no one is left without a home.”

“Providing housing with support reflects the values of a just society.”

“Everyone deserves the dignity of a safe and stable home.”

“Together, we can tackle homelessness and create lasting change.”

“Taking action today builds a better future for everyone.”

Economic Benefit



“Housing solutions save taxpayers money compared to emergency interventions.”

“Every dollar spent on housing yields long-term savings for communities.”

“Affordable housing boosts local economies and job creation.”

“Investing in housing lowers costs for public healthcare and policing.”

“Stable housing helps people return to work, strengthening the economy.”

Addressing Common Arguments for Criminalization





Why Criminalization Isn’t the Solution

Criminalization of homelessness often masquerades as a practical or compassionate solution, but closer examination reveals it to be both ineffective and costly. Instead of solving the root causes of homelessness, criminalization prolongs the cycle by creating barriers to stability and recovery. Yet, many people continue to believe in its necessity due to pervasive myths and misinformation. Legal decisions, such as the recent Grants Pass v. Johnson case, can reinforce or legitimize criminalization measures, creating a ripple effect in municipalities seeking similar policies.

Politically expedient, criminalization provides a visible, short-term response that appears to address homelessness by removing individuals from public spaces. It appeals to voters demanding immediate action, even though it fails to address root causes. Pro-criminalization arguments exploit fears about safety, property values, and public order. These emotional appeals often overshadow evidence-based discussions about effective solutions like Housing First.

This section equips you with factual counterarguments to the most common pro-criminalization claims. By pairing these counterpoints with tailored messaging strategies, you can appeal to people's common sense and sense of fairness, effectively addressing emotional and ideological resistance to housing-first approaches. In a time when social media amplifies false narratives about homelessness, an integrated approach grounded in data and empathy is essential.

Planned further studies will seek to answer how best to reconcile most people’s general aversion to criminalization from both a common-sense and empathy perspective with the pro-criminalization policies that are taking hold.

COMMON ARGUMENT #1

“Criminalization is the push people need to get themselves off the streets.”

EFFECTIVE COUNTERPOINTS:

- **Root Cause is Housing Costs:** Homelessness primarily results from unaffordable housing, not substance use or mental illness. Without stable housing, addressing other challenges becomes nearly impossible.
- **Housing Works:** Programs that provide immediate housing with supportive services are twice as effective and half as expensive as criminalization. Many cities have reduced homelessness using this approach.
- **Recovery Starts with Stability:** Safe, stable housing is a prerequisite for addressing mental health and substance use issues.

“Stable housing with supportive services is the proven way to help people recover. Criminalization only prolongs their homelessness.”

COMMON ARGUMENT #2

“Unhoused people choose to be homeless and refuse shelters.”

EFFECTIVE COUNTERPOINTS:

- **Barriers to Shelters:** Shelters often have rules that make them unfeasible, such as separating families, barring pets, or being unsafe.
- **Trust is Key:** Many unhoused people experience severe trauma. Building trust over time increases the likelihood they will accept housing.
- **Customizing Solutions:** Making housing options flexible (e.g., allowing pets, accommodating families) ensures more people say yes.

“Most unhoused people eventually choose housing when it’s safe, supportive, and meets their needs.”

COMMON ARGUMENT #3

“Criminalization is compassionate because it prevents severely mentally ill people from living on the streets.”

EFFECTIVE COUNTERPOINTS:

- **Compassion is Housing, Not Jail:** Jail exacerbates trauma and creates barriers to recovery, trapping people in homelessness.
- **Housing is Compassionate and Effective:** Stable housing allows individuals to access treatment and supportive services tailored to their needs.
- **Positive Outcomes:** Cities that prioritize housing and services report significant reductions in chronic homelessness and improved mental health outcomes.

“Putting people in jail doesn’t solve homelessness—it perpetuates it. Real compassion is providing housing and the support they need to thrive.”

COMMON ARGUMENT #4

“Unhoused people make public spaces unsafe for children and neighbors.”

EFFECTIVE COUNTERPOINTS:

- **Homeless People are Victims, Not Perpetrators:** Research shows that unhoused people are more likely to be victims of crime than perpetrators.
- **Ending Homelessness Ends Public Encampments:** By providing housing and supportive services, people are less likely to rely on public spaces for shelter.
- **Focus on Solutions, Not Displacement:** Criminalization only pushes unhoused people to other areas without addressing the root cause.
- **Encampment Sweeps:** don’t improve public safety, and can actually increase crime rates.

“Providing housing is the most effective way to keep public spaces safe and accessible for everyone.”

COMMON ARGUMENT #5

“Formerly homeless people will disrupt apartment buildings and neighborhoods.”

EFFECTIVE COUNTERPOINTS:

- **Supportive Housing Includes Case Management:** Housing and service programs ensure case managers are available to address issues that may arise between tenants or with landlords.
- **Proven Success:** Studies show that supportive housing doesn’t negatively impact property values or neighborhood safety.
- **No Alternatives:** Without housing, individuals remain unhoused, perpetuating the cycle of visible homelessness.

“Supportive housing creates stability, not disruption. Case managers help ensure a positive outcome for everyone.”

COMMON ARGUMENT #6

“Our community needs ordinances as a tool to help address homelessness.”

EFFECTIVE COUNTERPOINTS:

- **Ticketing and Jail Time Aren’t Solutions:** These ordinances aren’t tools to help resolve homelessness, they only set homeless people further back in life, perpetuating their state of homelessness. However, law enforcement officers can engage with homeless individuals and connect them to support services without resorting to arrest.
- **Criminalizing Homelessness Doesn’t Address Root Causes:** These measures can disproportionately punish people for their circumstances without providing meaningful solutions, such as affordable housing, mental health services, or job training.
- **Ordinances Can Strain Community Resources:** Resources required for enforcement by police, court systems, and administrative processes could be more effectively used for evidence-based interventions, such as housing-first programs or support services.

“Tickets don’t build apartments or heal addiction. Let’s invest in the root causes, not punishments.”

Messaging That Works

HARDEST ARGUMENTS TO ADDRESS:

“Forced treatment works.”

Recovery works best with autonomy and stable housing.

“Stable housing provides the foundation for people to voluntarily engage in treatment, producing the best outcomes”

“Homeless people are dangerous.”

Acknowledge people’s fear while reframing the narrative.

“Homeless people are more often victims of crime. Housing is the solution to creating safer communities.”

“I don’t want to live near a homeless person.”

Reframe concerns with facts.

“Supportive housing doesn’t negatively affect neighborhoods and includes case management to address any issues.”

THE MOST SUCCESSFUL STRATEGIES:

Focus on Evidence-Based Success:

Highlight cities and programs that have effectively reduced homelessness. Example: **“Houston reduced homelessness by 63% using a Housing First approach.”**

Share Personal Stories:

Real stories create emotional connections that move people to action—whether through altruism (a person rebuilding their life) or self-benefit (housing as the only permanent solution to encampments). **Data informs, but stories persuade.**

Criminalization Isn’t a Solution:

Emphasize how **jail makes it harder for people to exit homelessness.** Example: The 2024 Los Angeles Homeless Services Authority report showed that anti-camping ordinances don't work and cost taxpayers more.

Explain the Trauma of Homelessness:

Help audiences understand how **trauma impacts decision-making** and why **trust-building is essential.**

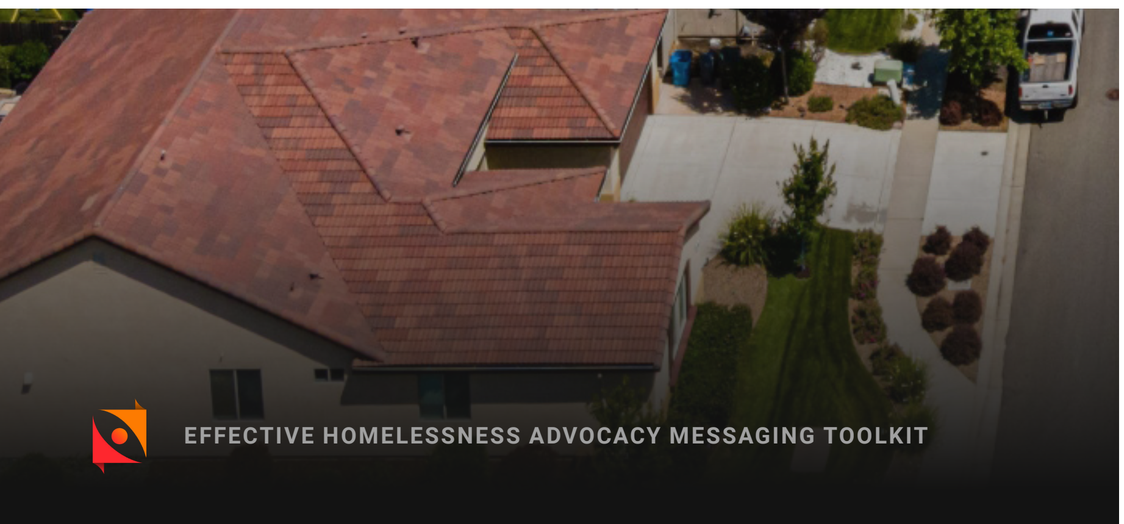


Lead with compassion, data, and proven solutions. Share stories that make the issue real, showing that prioritizing housing with supportive services works for individuals and communities alike.



About This Report





Research Methodology

ABSTRACT

This 1000 respondent study conducted in 2024 examined the effectiveness of altruistic versus self-benefit messaging across distinct demographic segments. By analyzing themes in messaging, we identify patterns in how different groups—based on income, age, political affiliation, and other factors—respond to specific phrase structures and framing styles. This analysis yields actionable insights on strategic message tailoring to increase engagement and influence based on demographic characteristics.

METHODOLOGY

The data analyzed were segmented by demographic groups, each assigned to clusters based on shared traits, including income levels, age ranges, and political affiliations. Messaging themes were categorized into two main types:

- **Altruistic Themes:** Emphasizing community support, collective responsibility, and societal benefit.
- **Self-Benefit Themes:** Focusing on personal security, individual growth, and self-reliance.

Phrase modeling was then applied to these themes, assessing their alignment with each demographic cluster.

DATA COLLECTION AND ANALYSIS

Data were collected from a survey, scored across various demographic segments. Respondents' alignment with altruistic or self-benefit messaging was analyzed using weighted influence scores, regression modeling, and variance analysis. Further expert insights were gathered to interpret the results based on behavioral economics, social psychology, and communications strategies.



About Us

Invisible People is a 501(c)(3) nonprofit dedicated to educating the public about homelessness through innovative storytelling, news, and advocacy. Since our launch in 2008, Invisible People has become a pioneer and trusted resource for inspiring action and raising awareness in support of advocacy, policy change and thoughtful dialogue around poverty in North America and the United Kingdom.

OUR MISSION

We imagine a world where everyone has a place to call home. Each day, we work to fight homelessness by giving it a face while educating individuals about the systemic issues that contribute to its existence. Through storytelling, education, news, and activism, we are changing the narrative on homelessness.

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